

Stress and Coping





- **Stress is a universal phenomenon. All individuals experience it. Parents refer to the stress of raising children, working individuals talk of the stress of their jobs, and students at all levels talk of the stress of school. Stress can result from both positive and negative experiences.**

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- **A stressor is any event or stimulus that causes an individual to experience stress.**
 - **When an individual faces stressors, responses are referred to as coping strategies, or coping responses**

TYPES OF STRESSORS

- Biological stressors
 - Any illness or disease
 - Disabilities
 - Injuries
- Environmental stressors
 - Poverty
 - Overcrowding
 - Natural disasters



Sources of Stress

- ♦ **Internal stressors:** originate within an individual as infection or feelings of depression.
- ♦ **External stressors:** originate outside the individual as a move to another city, a death in the family, or pressure from peers.

- ♦ **Developmental stressors:** occur at predictable times throughout an individual's life.
- ♦ **Situational stressors:** are unpredictable and may occur at any time during life. It may be positive or negative as death of a family member, marriage or divorce, birth of a child, new job, illness.

Effects of Stress

- ♦ **Physical effect:** stress can threaten an individual's physiologic homeostasis.
- ♦ **Emotional effect:** stress can produce negative feelings about the self.
- ♦ **Intellectual effect:** stress can influence an individual's perceptual and problem-solving abilities.

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- ♦ **Social effect:** stress can alter an individual's relationships with others.
 - ♦ **Spiritual effect:** stress can challenge one's beliefs and values.

Models of Stress

- Models of stress assist nurses to predict stressors in a particular situation and to understand the individual's responses.
- Three main models of stress are **stimulus based**, **response based**, and **transaction based**.

Stimulus Based Models

- ♦ In stimulus-based stress models, stress is defined as a **stimulus**, a life event, or a set of circumstances **that arouses physiologic and psychologic reactions** that may increase the individual's vulnerability to illness.

Response Based Models

- In response-based models stress may be considered as **a response**.
This definition was developed and described by Selye as “the **nonspecific response of the body** to any kind of demand made upon it” Selye’s stress response is **characterized by a chain or pattern of physiologic events** called the **general adaptation syndrome (GAS)** or stress syndrome.

- This response occurs with the release of certain adaptive hormones and subsequent changes in the structure and chemical composition of the body.
- With prolonged stress, deep ulcers appear in the lining of the stomach, the lymphatic structures enlarge considerably, such as the spleen, and lymph nodes. Besides adapting globally, the body can also react locally; that is, one organ or a part of the body reacts alone. This is referred to as **the local adaptation syndrome (LAS)**.



Three stages of the GAS and the LAS:

1. Alarm reaction

2. Resistance

3. Exhaustion

1. Alarm Reaction

The initial reaction of the body is the alarm reaction, which alerts the body's defenses.

Stage of Resistance

- The **second stage** in the GAS and LAS syndromes, the **stage of resistance**, is the **body attempts to cope with the stressor and to limit the stressor to the smallest area of the body that can deal with it.**

Stage of Exhaustion

- During the third stage, the stage of exhaustion, the adaptation that the body made during the second stage cannot be maintained. This means that the ways used to cope with the stressor have been exhausted.

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- If adaptation has not overcome the stressor, the stress effects may spread to the entire body.
 - At the end of this stage, the body may either rest and return to normal, or death may be the ultimate consequence.

Indicators of Stress

- Indicators of an individual's stress may be **physiologic**, **psychologic**, or **cognitive**.

Physiologic Indicators

- Responses to stress vary depending on the individual's perception of events.

The physiologic signs and symptoms of stress result from activation of the neuroendocrine systems of the body.

- ♦ Pupils dilate to increase visual perception when serious threats to the body arise.
- ♦ Sweat production (diaphoresis) increases to control elevated body heat.
- ♦ Heart rate and cardiac output increase to transport nutrients.
- Skin is pallid because of constriction of peripheral blood vessels.

- ♦ Sodium and water retention increase due to release of mineral corticoids.
- ♦ Rate and depth of respirations increase because of dilation of the bronchioles.
- ♦ Urinary output decreases but there may be urinary frequency or urgency.
- ♦ Mouth may be dry.

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- ♦ Possible constipation and flatus or diarrhea may occur.
 - ♦ Muscle tension increases to prepare for rapid motor activity or defense.
 - ♦ Blood sugar increases.

Psychologic Indicators

- **Anxiety and fear**
- **Anger:** A verbal expression of anger can be a signal to others of one's internal psychologic discomfort and a call for assistance to deal with perceived stress.
- **Depression:** is a common reaction to events that seem negative. It is an extreme feeling of sadness, despair, or lack of worth.

Cognitive Indicators

Problem-solving: involves thinking through the threatening situation, using specific steps to arrive at a solution.

- The individual assesses the situation or problem, analyzes or defines it, chooses alternatives, carries out the selected alternative, and evaluates whether the solution succeeded.

Self-control (discipline): is assuming a manner and facial expression that convey a sense of being in control.

- When self-control prevents panic and harmful or nonproductive actions in a threatening situation, it is a helpful response that conveys strength.

Examples of the Negative Effects of Stress on Basic Human Needs

Needs	Effects
Physiologic	Altered elimination pattern Change in appetite Altered sleep pattern
Safety and security	Expresses nervousness and feelings of being threatened
Love and belonging	Isolated and withdrawn Becomes overly dependent Blames others for own problems
Self-esteem	Fails to socialize with others
Self-actualization	Preoccupied with own problems Unable to accept reality

Coping

- **Is the cognitive and behavioral effort to manage specific external and/or internal demands that are appraised as taxing or exceeding the resources of the person.**

Types of coping strategies

- **Problem-focused coping:** refers to efforts to improve a situation by making changes or taking action.
- **Emotion-focused coping** includes thoughts and actions that relieve emotional distress. Emotion focused coping does not improve the situation, but the individual often feels better.

Coping strategies

Long-term coping strategies: can be **constructive and practical**.

- In certain situations, **talking with others and trying to find out more about the situation** are long-term strategies.
- long-term strategies include **a change in lifestyle patterns such as eating a healthy diet, exercising regularly, or using problem-solving in decision-making instead of anger.**

Short-term coping strategies: can reduce stress to a tolerable limit temporarily but are ineffective ways to permanently deal with reality.

- Examples of short-term strategies are using alcoholic beverages or drugs.

Coping also can be adaptive or maladaptive.

- **Adaptive coping:** helps the individual to deal effectively with stressful events and minimizes distress associated with them.
- **Maladaptive coping:** can cause unnecessary distress for the individual and others associated with the individual or stressful event.

Nursing management

- **Assessment**

(a) **Nursing history**

(b) **Physical examination of the client for indicators of stress (e.g., nail biting, nervousness, weight changes) or stress-related health problems (e.g., hypertension, dyspnea).**

- **During the physical examination, the nurse observes for verbal, motor, cognitive, or other physical manifestations of stress.**

• **Nursing Diagnosis**

- anxiety; caregiver stress; denial; and difficult coping (individual or family).

• **Planning**

- Decrease or resolve anxiety.
- Increase ability to manage or cope with stressful events or circumstances.



Implementation

- **Some methods to help reduce stress will be effective for one individual; other methods will be appropriate for a different individual.**



Encouraging Health Promotion Strategies e.g. physical exercise, optimal nutrition, adequate rest and sleep, and time management.



Exercise: Regular exercise promotes both physical and emotional health. Physiologic benefits include improved muscle tone, increased cardiopulmonary function, and weight control.

- ♦ Psychologic benefits include relief of tension, a feeling of well-being, and relaxation.



Nutrition

- ♦ Optimal nutrition is essential for health and in increasing the body's resistance to stress.
- ♦ Avoid excesses of caffeine, salt, sugar, and fat, and deficiencies in vitamins and minerals, to minimize the negative effects of stress (e.g., irritability, hyperactivity, anxiety).



Sleep

- ♦ Sleep restores the body's energy levels and is an essential aspect of stress management.
- ♦ To ensure adequate sleep, clients may need help to attain comfort.

Time Management

- ♦ Individuals who manage their time effectively usually experience less stress because they feel more in control of their circumstances.
- ♦ Clients who feel overwhelmed often need help to prioritize tasks and to consider whether modifications can be made to decrease role demands.
- ♦ Working parents, for example, may need to consider delegating tasks to family members or hiring part-time help.



Minimizing Anxiety

- ♦ Encourage clients to take deep breaths before any invasive procedure
e.g. injection
- ♦ Administer a massage to help the client relax,
- ♦ Offer support to clients and families during times of illness.

Using Relaxation Techniques

Several relaxation techniques can be used to quiet the mind, and release tension. Nurses can teach these techniques to clients. Nurses should also encourage clients to use these techniques when they encounter stressful health situations. Relaxation techniques include the following: breathing exercises, massage, and yoga.



Evaluating

Using the desired outcomes developed during the planning stage as a guide, the nurse collects data needed to determine whether client goals and outcomes have been achieved.